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The Perception of Reception: The Importance of Sir Thomas Roe at the Mughal Court of Jahangir*

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FOUNDED in 1526, the Timurid-Mughal dynasty of South Asia was a source of European fascination and interest, to which travelers were drawn by the promise of riches and the exotic. The establishment of direct sea links between Europe and South Asia in the early sixteenth century ushered in an era of diplomatic, commercial, and artistic exchange between these two regions, and saw representatives from Europe arrive at the court of the Great Mughal seeking permission to establish trade agreements beneficial to their home nations. The arrival of English envoys into the Mughal world was due solely to a desire to establish factories, a term used to denote European commercial compounds, within the Mughal Empire, and to have beneficial trade rights and safe passage for their ships in the Indian Ocean waters, then controlled by the Portuguese.¹ It was during the reign of the fourth

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¹ The Portuguese were the first Europeans to have a persistent presence in South Asia with the conquest of Goa in 1510 and the establishment of the *Estado da Índia*. They were therefore in direct conflict with English desires for trade relations with the Mughals. For an introduction to the Portuguese in India, see Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *The Portuguese Empire in Asia, 1500–1700: A Political and Economic History* (London: Longman, 1993); Nuno

Mughal *padshah*, or emperor, Nuruddin Muhammad Jahangir (r. 1605–1627), that the English continuously pressed for these desires.²

The most well-known Englishman at Jahangir's court was Sir Thomas Roe, sent as an official ambassador from King James I of England; in actuality, Roe held the dual role of representing the commercial entity of the East India Company. Roe was a prolific writer during his time in Jahangir's empire, keeping not only a detailed journal but also penning letters to business and personal contacts, and to James I. While Roe's writings have been used to illustrate the workings of the Mughal court and individual personalities present there, his personality is also revealed. The numerous frustrations and antagonistic relationship with certain members of the Mughal nobility shine through, as does the importance he associated with his position as a royal ambassador. Roe's constant validation of that role is evident in his writings through the stress he placed on his position at the Mughal court and the intimacy of his relationship with Jahangir. Using the writings of Sir Thomas Roe, in the form of his journal and letters, and the contemporary autobiographical memoirs of the Mughal emperor Jahangir, the *Jahangirnama*, this study will examine Roe's self-perceived importance at the Mughal court and the corresponding viewpoint of Jahangir. Jahangir's stance will be further elucidated through a discussion of significant examples of contemporary pictorial evidence.

Vassallo e Silva and Jorge Flores, *Goa and the Great Mughal* (Lisbon: Calouste Gulbenkian Museum, 2004); Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *From Biography to History: Essays in the History of Portuguese Asia, 1500–1800* (New Delhi: TransBooks, 2005); Y. Sharma and J. L. Ferreira, *Portuguese Presence in India during the Sixteenth and Seventeenth Centuries* (New Delhi: Viva Books, 2008).

² For primary sources on the English at Jahangir's court, see William Finch, *Observations of William Finch*, ed. Samuel Purchas (Glasgow: University of Glasgow Press, 1905), 4:1–77; Edward Terry, "A Relation of a Voyage to the Easterne India," in Purchas, *Hakluytus Posthumus; or, Purchas his Pilgrimes, containyng a History of the World in Sea Voyages and Lande Travells by Englishmen and others*, 20 vols. (Glasgow: James MacLehose, 1905), 9:1–54; William Foster, ed., *The Embassy of Sir Thomas Roe to India, 1615–1619, as narrated in his journal and correspondence* (London: Oxford University Press, 1926); J. Courtenay Locke, *The First Englishman in India, Letters and Narratives of Sundry Elizabethans* (London: Routledge, 1930). More recent studies of these travel writings include Kate Teltscher, *India Inscribed: European and British Writing on India 1600–1800* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1995); Colin Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe and the Mughal Empire* (Karachi: Mehran Printers, 2000); Richmond Barbour, *Before Orientalism: London's Theatre of the East 1576–1626* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003); Pramod Nayar, "Marvelous Excesses: English Travel Writing and India, 1608–1727," *Journal of British Studies* 44 (2005): 213–238; Sanjay Subrahmanyam, *Explorations in Connected History: Mughals and Franks* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2005).

Roe's appointment as royal ambassador followed numerous failed attempts by the English East India Company (hereafter the EIC) to establish a formal trade agreement with the Mughal court. Created by a consortium of wealthy merchants as a commercial entity in 1599, the EIC was subsequently granted a royal charter in 1600. In 1603 John Mildenhall became the first EIC representative to visit the Mughal court during the reign of Akbar (r. 1556–1605), Jahangir's father. However, it was the third EIC voyage in 1608 that attempted to establish formal trade relations with the Mughals. The delegation was led by William Hawkins, one of the lieutenant-generals of the third voyage, but his efforts failed, as did those of a sixth voyage in 1611. It was not until their tenth voyage that the EIC again tried to institute a formal trade agreement with the Mughals. In this instance, Thomas Best, the leader of that voyage, successfully obtained a *firman* in January 1613 that granted the English permission to build a factory in Surat.³ However, as a firm commercial treaty had still not been established between England and the Mughal Empire, the EIC convinced King James I to send an official royal ambassador to Jahangir's court, Sir Thomas Roe.⁴ Roe arrived at Surat in September 1615 at the age of thirty-five, firm in his resolve to represent himself, his king, and his country in a manner that would command respect and achieve the ultimate goal of a formal commercial agreement between the EIC and the Mughal emperor. Roe was at the royal court in Ajmer from January 1616 until August 1618, before returning to England in February 1619. The journal he kept while in the Mughal Empire is regarded as one of the premier European sources for information on the Mughal court.⁵ Roe's writings have therefore been frequently used as a factual account of happenings and occurrences at Jahangir's court, as Roe was seen to be providing a window into that private world.

Roe's texts exist as part of a wider corpus of "travel writing" published for the enjoyment of people desirous to know more about the

³ On the English's attempt to establish trading rights with the Mughal Empire, see Judith Farrington, "The First Twelve Voyages of the English East India Company, 1601–13: A Guide to Sources," *Indonesia and the Malay World* 29 (2001): 141–160; Foster, *Embassy*; William Hawkins, "Captaine William Hawkins," in Purchas, *Hakluytus Posthumus*.

⁴ Roe's position was complicated by the fact that his primary purpose at the Mughal court was one of trade. He was nominated by and in the pay of the EIC, having only a paper from James I endorsing his position as a royal ambassador (see Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, p. 2). For a lucid account of Roe's early career and the dual nature of his role as royal envoy and commercial ambassador, see Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*, and the preface to Foster's *Embassy*.

⁵ Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*, p. 26.

travelers, the places they visited, or (in this instance) the non-European seventeenth-century world. The complexity of analyzing travel writing is acute, however, and it is only in relatively recent research that their examination has moved beyond a descriptive nature. For example, Kate Teltscher has explored the writings of seventeenth-century English travelers in India to investigate how their attitudes anticipate the era of colonial writing and the emergence of the associated discourse. Her correlation between the seventeenth-century works with colonial writings on South Asia once the English transitioned from merchants to a ruling entity is a pertinent observation.⁶ Recent studies have examined Roe's writings with a view to exploring aspects of his persona. Colin Mitchell has reevaluated Roe's diplomatic interactions at the Mughal court by exploring how his background, religious viewpoints, and multiple positions in the European diplomatic sphere impacted his expectations and behavior. Furthermore, Mitchell has examined how Roe collated his different personas of ambassador, courtier, politician, historian, and *litterateur* into one while undertaking his dual role at Jahangir's court, as both royal and merchant ambassador.

Power issues permeate Roe's writings, in which Roe tried to present an "impression of ordered authority," a theme Teltscher has identified as one of the important aims of seventeenth-century English travel writing. Being able to convey the image of authority was, at times, more important than actually having any authority in practice. This contradiction is exemplified by Roe in his positions as royal ambassador and as an EIC employee. Barbour highlights that while Roe's royal letter of introduction to Jahangir from James I presented Roe as the king's spokesman, in a separate correspondence to Roe, James I is very clear that Roe's position as ambassador was subordinate to the wishes of the EIC, whose orders he was to follow and "in noe wise to digresse, as you will answeare the Contrarie at your perill."⁷

⁶ See the discussion in her introduction to *India Inscribed*. Other recent studies that have approached the examination of travel writing with an aim at readdressing how these texts should be understood include Subrahmanyam, *Connected History*; Pramod Nayar, *Colonial Voices: The Discourses of Empire* (Chichester, U.K.: Wiley-Blackwell, 2012). On English travel writing in particular for this period, see Richmond Barbour, "Power and Distant Display: Early English 'Ambassadors' in Moghul India," *Huntington Library Quarterly* 61 (1998): 343–368; Barbour, *Before Orientalism*; Richmond Barbour, "The East India Company Journal of Anthony Marlowe, 1607–1608," *Huntington Library Quarterly* 71 (2008): 255–301; Pramod Nayar, *English Writing and India, 1600–1920* (London: Routledge, 2008).

⁷ Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, pp. 154–155.

It is thus easy to understand Barbour's claim that Roe's success as an ambassador was dependent on his ability to theatrically demonstrate his power and position at the Mughal court. This endeavor was made more difficult by the behaviors and actions of previous EIC representatives who arrived at the Mughal court claiming the title of "ambassador."⁸ John Mildenhall had promised Akbar in 1603 that England would soon send a royal ambassador to his court. Jahangir took Hawkins to be this individual on his arrival in Agra in 1608, a charge Hawkins accepted even though he did not have the official capacity to do so. He was accepted into the court and given a living allowance and other signs of favor, but was ultimately turned away when he arrived at the court while drunk. Such actions by Hawkins and other claiming to be ambassadors caused Roe much consternation: "At the name of an ambassador they laughd one upon a nother; it beeing become ridiculous, so many having assumed the title, and not performed the offices; . . . I mention these only to lett the Company understand how meanly an ambassador was esteemed at my landing."⁹

The notion of theatrical politics has also been addressed by Sanjay Subrahmanyam, whose analysis of both Roe and the EIC as political actors in their engagement with the Mughal Empire stressed the conflict inherent in the political and trade negotiations Roe was there to undertake.¹⁰ Teltscher too makes use of this analogy, identifying Roe's descriptions of Jahangir's court in terms synonymous with contemporary English theatre as a means to personally understand the alien society he found himself in. By doing so, Roe was able to write about the Mughal courtly environment in conceptually familiar terms to himself and, ultimately, to his readers.¹¹ The idea of the theatrical nature of Roe's portrayal of himself and the Mughal court within his writings serves as a base for further discussion of Roe's own image within his words, which can be identified as a further aspect of Roe's *dramatis personae*, but one intended for a European rather than Mughal audience.

⁸ See Barbour, "Power and Distant Display." For a good summation on Englishmen who tarnished the image of the ambassador's office, see Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, pp. 147–151.

⁹ Foster, *Embassy*, p. 30. For a detailed study on this particular point, see Barbour, "Power and Distant Display," pp. 343–368; and chapter 4, "Sir Thomas Roe as Ambassador," in Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*.

¹⁰ Subrahmanyam, *Connected Histories*, pp. 143–172.

¹¹ Teltscher, *India Inscribed*, pp. 20–21.

SELF-PERCEPTION: ROE ON HIS IMPORTANCE
AT THE MUGHAL COURT

England's reputation as a country of little importance to Mughal trade and diplomacy became evident to Roe on his arrival in Surat and heightened his belief that the impression he gave of himself, which would be equated with the impression of his king and country, was of the utmost importance. This resulted in Roe thoroughly engaging with politics of display and presentation; he was a player in a scene and had to consistently maintain the character of "ambassador" if it was to be believed by his Mughal audience.¹² This theme was reflected in Roe's writings on Jahangir's court and colored many of his anecdotes and entries. A few key themes that emerge from Roe's texts are important to note for this study, one of which has already been stated: Roe's belief that his position made him the embodiment of James I and of England in South Asia. Next, his expectation that the rank of ambassador would be awarded a special status and that Roe's treatment by the Mughals should reflect this. This status translated into Roe's belief that he personally was held in very high esteem by Jahangir and shared a level of intimacy with him not afforded to other foreigners. Last, it will be seen that Roe insinuated himself into the hierarchy of the Mughal court. Roe likely intended for his journal and letters to be widely distributed, an idea supported not only by Roe's personality but also by the fact that he made copies of his journal while in South Asia and sent them to his friends and to the EIC.¹³ Bearing this in mind, the persistent insinuation in Roe's texts of his perceived importance at the Mughal court and to Jahangir takes on an added layer of meaning: The theatricality of his position in Mughal South Asia actually extended back to England, where his "character" would be received by a wider audience.

¹² Barbour, "Power and Distant Display," p. 345.

¹³ Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*, p. 33. Interest in European travel writing is not a new phenomenon. In the seventeenth century, soon after many of these travelers returned to Europe, edited versions of their writings were made available to a wider audience through compilations created by Richard Hakluyt (d. 1616) and Samuel Purchas (d. 1626); that they were interested distributing a wide range of travel literature speaks to the fact that there was a great desire for these types of works to be made available to the public. Hakluyt's first major publication, *The Principall Navigations, Voiages and Discoveries of the English Nation*, was published in 1589; in this work he relied heavily on eyewitness accounts of Englishmen who had traveled to Asia and the Americas. Purchas was also interested in the stories of those who had gone on sea voyages. He inherited a number of unsorted manuscripts from Hakluyt, which he combined with other travel narratives he collected into his multivolume *Purchas His Pilgrimes*, a series on world travel and exploration.

Roe's habitual response to any perceived lack of respect was to raise the specter of his royal commission. That this attitude was in place from a very early stage in his dealings with the Mughal nobility is clear from an incident that took place on his arrival in Surat. Before leaving for the royal court at Ajmer, Roe's belongings and those of his entourage were searched without his permission;¹⁴ he took this as a personal insult to his dignity as a royal ambassador. His response to the local governor, who came to beg his pardon after Roe sent Jahangir a messenger appraising him of these happenings, was the following: "I answered it was now too late: I only came to lett him see the king had better estimation of Ambassadors and theyre qualetye then he."¹⁵ The persistent ideology that Roe wished to project from the moment of his arrival in South Asia is clear: that as an ambassador he was to be permitted special rights, and he would not suffer himself to be used in any fashion he deemed disrespectful to himself and his king.

Once Roe arrived at Jahangir's court in Ajmer, his writings reflect an intimacy with the emperor unsurpassed by any other European. It is interesting to note that while projecting his self-perceptions of esteem and importance to Jahangir, Roe's writings also indicate to his English audience that as England's representative, Roe was held in higher esteem than any other European at the court. Thus, when Roe wrote that Jahangir esteemed him more than any other Frank,¹⁶ "Frank" would have been understood by an English reader to mean the Portuguese and the Jesuits.¹⁷ Furthermore, due to Roe's self-perceived equivalence with James I and England, stating Jahangir's preference for him suggested to his readers that Jahangir considered England politically superior to

¹⁴ It was the custom that all goods and belongings were searched on arrival by Mughal officials. Roe, however, felt that he and his entourage should have diplomatic immunity against such an act and so refused to allow the searches to take place.

¹⁵ Foster, *Embassy*, p. 85.

¹⁶ Thomas Roe, *The Embassy of Sir Thomas Roe to the Court of the Great Mogul, 1615–1619: As Narrated in His Journal and Correspondence*, ed. William Foster (London: Hakluyt Society, 1899), p. 257. (This edition will be differentiated from the 1926 version by the latter being designated as Foster's and former as Roe's.)

¹⁷ The Portuguese were established fixtures within the Mughal court since the 1580s, when the first Jesuit mission to Akbar's court was received. Since then, Jesuit fathers advised the emperor in his general dealings with Europeans and acted as translators and interpreters when other Europeans came to court. On the Jesuits at the Mughal court, see Antonio Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate on His Journey to the Court of Akbar*, trans. J. S. Hoyland (London: Oxford University Press, 1922); Father Pierre du Jarric, *Akbar and the Jesuits*, trans. C. H. Payne, ed. Sir E. D. Ross and E. Power (London: George Routledge and Sons, 1926); Father Fernao Guerreiro, *Jahangir and the Jesuits*, trans. C. H. Payne (London: George Routledge and Sons, 1930); Edward Maclagan, *The Jesuits and the Great Mogul* (London: Burns, Oates and Washborne Ltd, 1932).

Portugal. Roe stressed that it was not just amongst Europeans that he was considered superior, but among all foreign visitors, for when he was dismissed from Jahangir's presence, it was "with more favour and outward grace . . . than ever was sheowed to any ambassador, eyther of the Turke or Persian, or other whatsoever."¹⁸

Roe notes many additional circumstances and different situations in his writings to illustrate his importance to Jahangir, including when the *padshah* sent for Roe at night to help him tie on a sword and scarf in the "English fashion."¹⁹ This information, contained within a letter to the EIC, is Roe exhibiting to those who hired him his intimate access to Jahangir, indicating that he was in a position to fulfill the desires of the EIC. The inclusion of such anecdotal stories in Roe's writings was imperative for him to ensure the EIC's belief in the ultimate success of his embassy.²⁰

Roe also used alternate methods to highlight his perceived importance to Jahangir. By writing of events that took place in his absence, Roe directly presented his readers with Jahangir's words and opinions instead of his own.²¹ When it was relayed to Jahangir that Roe was unhappy, Roe writes that Jahangir demanded to know, saying that he had used Roe with more respect than any other stranger and never given the Englishman cause to doubt him.²² Roe used Jahangir's words, therefore, to again allude to the *padshah* considering him to be more important than any other foreigner at the court. This mark of favor was further made explicit by Roe conveying that Jahangir invited him to drink with the emperor's intimates on Jahangir's birthday,²³ by stating that Jahangir was perturbed that Roe missed the associated ritual weighing ceremony of the emperor,²⁴ and in the multiple instances recounted by Roe in which he was sent wild animals killed by the emperor himself, a mark of great favor.

The discussion of Roe thus far has focused on the written conveyance of his importance to Jahangir. In conjunction to these are exam-

¹⁸ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 109. This sentiment was repeated in a letter written to Lord Carew: "The King never used any Ambassadors with so much respect," p. 112.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 118.

²⁰ The importance of such projection has been discussed by Subrahmanyam. See his *Connected Histories*, p. 152.

²¹ It should be remembered that because Roe did not speak or understand Persian, the court language, whenever he relays Mughal words and opinions in his writing, the words have gone through a filtering process via interpreters and/or word of mouth.

²² Roe, *Embassy*, p. 187.

²³ *Ibid.*, p. 256.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 252.

ples of how Roe consciously placed himself into the Mughal court hierarchy, and in doing so perpetuated this projection of perceived importance. Roe insinuated himself into the court ceremonial structure in such a way that he held the position of a top-ranking courtier in his proscribed location in the *darbar*, the audiences Jahangir held with his nobles. Court ceremonial dictated that when the emperor was in *darbar*, courtiers and nobles were placed around the audience hall in accordance with their rank, and only the closest advisors and highest-ranking nobles were placed within a particular set of rails closest to the emperor. With this awareness of hierarchy in the *darbar*, the following series of events recounted by Roe are particularly important occurrences, relating to the often-mentioned fact that Roe was permitted within this railed section of the *darbar*.

On 24 January 1616, Roe “went to the *Darbar* to visitt the King, who, seeing mee afarr off, beckned with his hand, giuing signe I should not staye the Cerimony of Asking leaue but Come vp to him; where hee appoynted me a place aboue all other men, which *I after thought fitt* to mayntayne”²⁵ (italics mine). Roe’s statement intimates a particular level of closeness with the emperor, who saw him at a distance and called him forward. Jahangir is presented as showing Roe preferential treatment in that Roe did not have to formally ask permission to approach the imperial space and was therefore not required to follow the rigid nature of courtly audience. That Roe had already independently decided that he would continue to distinguish himself in *darbar* by returning to the same place behind the rails that on this particular occasion he was permitted to enter by Jahangir highlights the part Roe played in the creation of his position at court.²⁶

This event was followed by Roe’s request to stand by Jahangir’s throne at the Nouruz²⁷ festivities on 15 March 1616; Roe was granted permission to choose a place to stand as a result of this request.²⁸ “At Euening I went to the *Norose* and demanded of Asaph Chan”²⁹ a place.

²⁵ Foster, *Embassy*, p. 115.

²⁶ It is interesting to note that while through his actions Roe placed himself within the court structure and hierarchy, through actions such as refusing to perform the customary greeting Roe purposefully remained outside of it. This purposeful separation has been noted too by Teltscher, who in this context refers to Roe as “defiantly independent.” See Teltscher, *India Inscribed*, p. 22.

²⁷ The Nouruz is the Persian celebration of the New Year, taking place in spring. It was a large-scale annual celebration at the Mughal court.

²⁸ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 149.

²⁹ Asaf Khan was the brother of Nur Jahan Begum and therefore Jahangir’s brother-in-law. He was also Prince Khurram’s (Shah Jahan’s) father-in-law and a high-ranking courtier within the government.

Hee bad me Choose; so I went within the rayle, and stood on the right hand of the kynge upon the rising of the Throne; the Prince and young Ranna on the other Syde.”³⁰ While the permission to choose his own place came from Jahangir, it was Roe’s personal choice of placement that saw him enter the rails again and make a statement of distinction by equating himself with the royal family. Although the Nouruz took place almost two months after Roe’s visit to the *darbar* in which Jahangir signaled him to stand within the rails, Roe took it upon himself to return to that same location which he thought “fit to maintain.”

This appropriation of space and Roe’s equation of the location he had at *darbar* with his perceived importance is further emphasized by a passage in his journal about a visit to the court on 26 March:

I keeping the Place which I first tooke, alone and out of ranck which the kings subjects obserue, a place dessigned mee by the king, the place giuen to Sir Robert Sherly,³¹ and indeed aboue all his subjectes, Asaph Chan sent mee a message to goe downe and stand by the door among the kings servants. I answered: if the king Commanded, I knew what I had to doe, but to stirr for any other I would not. He sent againe that it was not the Custome for any to stand alone: that I should goe backe in the ranck of noble men. I replied: I was a stranger and ignorant of their Customes, but I was not ignorant that I was a kings Ambassador, and not of the qualty of seruants; that his maiestie had placed mee and saw mee now; if I did amisse hee was fittest to find faulte: if it were his pleasure I should goe home, I was ready, but one foote back I would not. . . . Then hee sent an Officer to Fright mee, but I went so much higher and nearer the king; and standing awhile without molestation, alone and euerie bodyes eyes cast vpon mee, I saw place wherein stood only the Prince and young Ranna by the king, to which I went, resolving, if I must rancke, I would rancke with the best. This angered Asaph Chan, who euer sought to woorke me to the humilitey of my predecessors.³²

³⁰ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 150.

³¹ Jahangir received the Englishman Robert Sherley in Ajmer favorably, gave him presents, and promised to give him justice in relation to his treatment at the hands of the governor and viceroy of Sind. Sherley stayed in Agra for ten days before departing for the Safavid court around 25 September 1614. See Purchas, *Purchas His Pilgrimes Part 2*, Book 10 (London: 1625), p. 1806; and Boies Penrose, *The Sherleian Odyssey* (Taunton: Barmicotts Ltd, 1938), p. 195.

³² Roe, *Embassy*, pp. 151–152. This illustrates very well the sentiment Roe wrote to the Bishop of Canterbury in a letter dated 30 October 1616, “Breefly, I stand on very fickle termes, though in extraordinarie Grace with the King, who is gentle, soft and good of disposition.” The “fickle terms” he speaks of relate to Prince Khurram and his followers, of which Asaf Khan was one, which is thus contrasted with the attitude of Jahangir toward Roe. See Roe, *Embassy*, p. 310.

This particular passage is rife with interesting information. First, Roe's stress on the singularity of his position, and that he considered it to have been appointed him by Jahangir. Then, that Roe knew of Robert Sherley being permitted to take the same position during his visit to Jahangir's court in 1614, and so felt that he had a right to stand there. However, this information implies that Jahangir allowed other Europeans to take this position of prestige at the *darbar*, indicating that Roe being allotted that space once by the emperor was not a distinction for Roe alone. From this passage it is also seen that Roe equated the court nobles with servants, and that he as an ambassador ranked above all of them; the passage further states that he was resolved to rank with only the best, in this case, with the royal family. In addition, the last line of the above passage makes it clear that Roe's actions were informed by the treatment of previous EIC representatives, and that he would not allow himself to be handled in the same way. A final remark on this passage is due, pertaining to Roe's purposeful display of himself to the Mughal court: his theatrical placement resulted in every eye being on him, so that he was observed by the emperor and all his subjects.

Another aspect of Roe's self-perceived importance to Jahangir comes across in the competition he felt with other diplomatic visitors, which came to a head with the arrival at the Mughal court of the Safavid ambassador, Muhammad-Riza Beg. Roe's request for permission before his first appearance at the court to "use the customes of my country" in greeting Jahangir was granted,³³ thereby ensuring he would not have to perform the (in his eyes) demeaning customary acts of obeisance that all who come before the emperor were required to do: the *taslim*, bowing before the emperor, and *sizeda*, when the visitor kneeled on the floor and touched their forehead to the ground three times. Roe felt that his decision to not perform this greeting distinguished him as a more important individual than those who did, but also projected England as an equal, not subordinate, nation to the Mughal Empire. The disdain Roe felt for those who did *taslim* is evident in his writings on Muhammad-Riza Beg. Roe referred to Muhammad-Riza frequently in his journal and letters during the Safavid's time at court; this has been discussed elsewhere in terms of the theatrical nature of Roe's description of Muhammad-Riza's arrival and gift-giving ceremony, in which the "character" of Muhammad-Riza differs drastically from that being played by the English ambassador.³⁴

³³ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 108.

³⁴ Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, p. 180; Teltscher, *India Inscribed*, p. 21.

The consistent attitude Roe exhibited toward Muhammad-Riza exemplifies Roe's perceived importance and projects him as a more favorable ambassador. Consequently, Roe used these musings to project to his readership that Jahangir esteemed England as a nation more than Safavid Iran. Roe's notation on the arrival and reception of Muhammad-Riza at the Mughal court on 19 October 1616 makes this plain. Although curious to know of his arrival and reception, Roe sent his secretary to view how the Safavid ambassador was received.³⁵

When hee approached, he made three *teselims* and one *sizeda* (which is prostrating himselfe and knocking his head against the Ground); at the entrance in, the like; and so presented the Shabas his letter; which the kinge took with a little motion of his body, asking only: How doth my brother? without the title of Maiestie; and after some few woordes hee was Placed in the seauenth rannck against the rayle by the doore, below so many of the kinges seruantes on both sides, which in my Iudgment was a most inferior Place for his masters Embassador, but that hee well deserued it for dooing that reuerence . . . to the dishonor of his Prince and the Murmer of many of his Nation.³⁶

Roe's contempt for Muhammad-Riza is clear, as is the allusion that Roe was a superior ambassador and James I a more relevant ruler to Jahangir than Shah Abbas. Roe's specific inclusion of the placement accorded Muhammad-Riza in the seventh rank was no doubt meant to remind the reader that Roe was accorded and then maintained a placement within the *darbar* that was on par with the royal princes. Roe related the insulting, inferior placement of the Persian ambassador directly to his performance of the ritual greeting, for in doing so, Muhammad-Riza dishonored himself and the Shah. Roe's particular mention of Jahangir referring to Shah Abbas as his brother and not as "Majesty" differentiated how he believed Jahangir viewed James I and Shah Abbas. For Roe, Jahangir denied the Shah acknowledgement of royalty by not referring to him as "Majesty," a title not omitted when Jahangir referred to James I. This was further evident to Roe in how Jahangir received Shah Abbas's letter, which Roe perceived as being less favorable than how he received James I's.³⁷ This sentiment was repeated in a letter to Lord Carew: "The King never vsed any Ambasadour with so much respect; without any dispute giuing mee leaut to

³⁵ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 295.

³⁶ *Ibid.*, pp. 295–296.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 296.

vse mine owne customes, not requiring that of me, which he vseth of the Persian . . . He . . . said the King and he were brothers, with many other courteous words.”³⁸

Roe continually emphasized his perceived importance over that of the Persian ambassador by the repetition of Muhammad-Riza’s lower status in the *darbar*. After Muhammad-Riza presented his first round of gifts to Jahangir, “he returned with many antique trickes to his Place, far inferior to that allowed mee, which was alone and aboue all subjectese.”³⁹ In addition to writing about the placement in his journal, Roe noted in correspondence with the bishop of Canterbury that Muhammad-Riza arrived at court and demeaned himself by doing the customary prostrations and obeisance.⁴⁰ Furthermore, “He is not allowed so good rancke nor Presence in Court as I, which I gott by dispute, and haue kept it by Contention, to the displeasure of some; neither did the King doe soe much honour in reception of his Masters lettre, not vouchsafing once to giue any title of Maiestie to the Persian as of my Soueraygne Lord, which not a little Contented mee.”⁴¹ In a separate letter written to the EIC, while discussing his monetary troubles, Roe again referred to Muhammad-Riza pejoratively: “I could sooner dye then be subject to the slauery the Persian is content with,”⁴² referring to Muhammad-Riza’s acceptance of gifts and money from Jahangir and his performance of the ritual greetings.

Roe’s journal entries and letters to England contain, as has been shown, anecdotes and instances in which he stressed the importance (as he saw it) of his own place at the Mughal court, an importance which he puts down to Jahangir’s preference for him. Roe’s self-perceived partiality by Jahangir is in spite of Roe’s deliverance of meager gifts to the emperor, gifts that were compared most unfavorably to those brought by other diplomatic visitors to the Mughal court. Roe wrote to Lord Carew that it was only by giving gifts to the emperor that people could move up within the ranks of the Mughal nobility, and how favorites were raised to postings of power.⁴³ By acknowledging to Carew that Roe’s own gifts were meager, but stating his placement within the court as being more favorable than others, including

³⁸ Ibid., p. 112.

³⁹ Roe, *Embassy*, p. 301.

⁴⁰ Ibid., p. 311.

⁴¹ Ibid.

⁴² Ibid., pp. 350–351.

⁴³ Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*, pp. 106–107.

Muhammad-Riza, Roe gave the impression that he was able to operate outside the established system; yet again Roe finds a way to imply his perceived self-importance at Jahangir's court. Returning to the earlier discussed concept of Roe as an actor and the Mughal court as a stage, stretching this simile further, Roe's stress on his placement at court, and in how Jahangir showed him preference, can be interpreted as discreet *mise-en-scènes* within his writings in which he placed himself at the center of the Mughal court structure, literally at the side of Jahangir. It is imperative to remember, however, that those distinctions that were of an exceptionally theatrical nature in their occurrences at *darbar* were very much a product of Roe's own actions and not maintained due to preferential treatment by Jahangir.

SIR THOMAS ROE AND ENGLAND IN JAHANGIR'S WORLDVIEW

In stark contrast to the way Roe projected himself as an integral part of Jahangir's court, Europeans are almost completely omitted in Jahangir's memoirs. The *Jahangirnama* is a factual account of Jahangir's reign and an important representation of the emperor's personality, reflecting a candid individual discussing his flaws, attributes, addictions, dislikes, and even self-designed scientific experiments.⁴⁴ Furthermore, Jahangir names with great frequency courtiers, nobles, rivals, enemies, and visiting dignitaries to his court. Such details captured the court around him as he saw it, a point that must be emphasized: In the *Jahangirnama* is the Mughal court as *Jahangir* saw it. The *Jahangirnama* is thus a true window into Jahangir's worldview.⁴⁵

While European monarchs never appear within the *Jahangirnama*, there are numerous references to Shah Abbas as well as former Safavid shahs. Perhaps as a concession to the established presences of the Portuguese state centered at Goa, the *Jahangirnama* contains a few references to the Viceroy.⁴⁶ Referencing the Portuguese more broadly,

⁴⁴ Nuruddin Muhammad Jahangir, *The Jahangirnama, Memoirs of Jahangir, Emperor of India*, trans. ed., and annot. Wheeler M. Thackston (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999).

⁴⁵ In her study of the *Jahangirnama*, Corinne Lefèvre has emphasized that while Jahangir has gained a reputation as a pleasure-loving drunk with little interest in ruling his empire, in fact his memoirs contain many instances of his displayed interest in politics. See Corinne Lefèvre, "Recovering a Missing Voice from Mughal India: The Imperial Discourse of Jahangir (r. 1605–1627) in His Memoirs," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 4, no. 50 (2007): 452–489.

⁴⁶ Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, p. 133.

Jahangir also refers a few times to the “Franks of Goa.”⁴⁷ Direct reference to the English is a singular occurrence, when Jahangir refers to them literally as “the English” in relation to their defeat of the Portuguese in a sea battle.⁴⁸

This bias against Europeans is further apparent in the multiple times emissaries and ambassadors from Asian nations are mentioned by Jahangir. This discrepancy in the *Jahangirnama*, and consequently the lack of correlation between how Roe thought he was viewed by Jahangir and how Jahangir perceived him, will be explored by first discussing Asian diplomats in the *Jahangirnama*.

In contrast with the more descriptive passages in Roe’s journal on the arrival and reception of Muhammad-Riza Beg, Jahangir’s account of the Safavid ambassador at his court is more concise. Muhammad-Riza arrived at the court on 30 October 1616, and that evening Jahangir talked with “my brother Abbas’ emissary”; further to this, Jahangir gifted Muhammad-Riza an elephant, a great mark of royal favor.⁴⁹ On 31 March 1617 Jahangir wrote that he gave Muhammad-Riza permission to leave the court, and on his departure was given gifts for himself and for “my brother Abbas.”⁵⁰ This entry was followed by the inclusion in the *Jahangirnama* that Muhammad-Riza died of dysentery in Agra, en route to Iran.⁵¹ Although brief, Jahangir’s writings on Muhammad-Riza are of particular significance in that they indicate his acknowledgment of the Safavid ambassador, his worth as an ambassador (evidenced in the gift giving), and the projection of royal kinship between Shah Abbas and Jahangir. Jahangir corroborates, then, Roe’s writing of the emperor’s reference to Abbas as “my brother,” but whereas Roe perceived that as a sign of decreased importance and a slight, Jahangir used it as a sign of intimacy. More important, however, is that while Roe projected Muhammad-Riza as a less distinguished ambassador than he in his writings, it is Muhammad-Riza and Shah Abbas, and not Roe and James I, who appear in the *Jahangirnama*.

Contrasting with the singularity of Muhammad-Riza’s presence in Roe’s journal, in the *Jahangirnama* multiple ambassadors from the Safavid court are mentioned. The first is Husayn Beg in 1607, whom

⁴⁷ For example, “The Franks of Goa had broken their word and plundered in the vicinity of the port of Surat four foreign ships that frequented that port.” Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, p. 154.

⁴⁸ Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, p. 165.

⁴⁹ Ibid., pp. 201, 203.

⁵⁰ Ibid., p. 219.

⁵¹ Ibid., p. 230.

Jahangir gifted ten thousand rupees to. The context of this inclusion in the *Jahangirnama* is interesting, as Jahangir wrote that he rose in rank and promoted several courtiers; Husayn Beg was the only one named and whose gift was precisely noted.⁵² This distinction given to a Safavid diplomat was repeated when Jahangir named Yadgar Ali as paying homage in 1612, when he presented gifts and a letter to Jahangir from “my brother Abbas,” whose letter Jahangir copied into his memoirs.⁵³ A few years later in 1615 the Safavid emissary Mustafa Beg was at the court, to whom Jahangir awarded twenty thousand drabs, a jeweled belt, and a *mohur* worth six thousand rupees.⁵⁴ Yet another Safavid ambassador named was Sayyid Hassan in 1620; Jahangir wrote of giving him some particularly fine apples from Bangash, a seemingly frivolous bit of information until Jahangir made it known that they were the best he had ever tasted and was therefore showing Sayyid Hassan a mark of distinction by giving him some.⁵⁵ Multiple Safavid emissaries were at the Mughal court concurrently, for Jahangir grouped four together in the following passage: “At this time I gave leave to depart to Aqa Beg, Muhibb-Ali, Fazil Beg, and Hajji Beg, emissaries of the ruler of Iran who had come at various times.”⁵⁶ In 1620 Qasim Beg arrived as a Safavid emissary and paid homage, “bringing a letter from that magnificent brother of mine.”⁵⁷

The inclusion of diplomatic visitors within the *Jahangirnama* was a means by which Jahangir indicated his importance, supported by his referencing visiting diplomats from other Asian courts as well, such

⁵² Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, p. 68.

⁵³ *Ibid.*, pp. 121–123. Jahangir copied complete correspondence between himself and Shah Abbas into the *Jahangirnama* (see also pp. 383–385), and while he did not for any other nation, he made note of a letter he wrote to ‘Adil Khan, the Deccani sultan of Bijapur (pp. 413–414). Further references appear in the text to the sultans of Gujarat and Bijapur, and of interactions between the courts; for example, Jahangir writes of Bakhtar Khan Kalawant from Bijapur, who he described as being “intimately connected with ‘Adil Khan,” and so was perhaps at Jahangir’s court as an emissary (p. 163). In the case of England, while it is known that Jahangir wrote two letters to James I, nothing of this appeared in the *Jahangirnama*. In Foster, *Embassy*, pp. 504–502, are Roe’s English versions of these Mughal letters.

⁵⁴ Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, pp. 173, 180.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, pp. 306, 310.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 365. Furthermore, Jahangir recounts the gifts he had been given by each and the gifts he in turn was sending to the shah. Aqa Beg and Muhibb-Ali were also named on 10 February 1620, when Jahangir wrote of their arrival at court to pay homage and deliver a letter from “my exalted brother,” and a third time when Jahangir noted the gifts sent to him by Shah Abbas. See pp. 357–358.

⁵⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 365. This distinction given to the Persian ambassadors continued in 1622, when Haydar Beg and Wali Beg are named emissaries from the ruler of Iran who arrived at court (p. 383). Furthermore, Jahangir mentions “Zaynal Beg, the ambassador” (p. 358), followed by another reference to him (p. 377).

as the fact that Quli Khan of Turan sent an emissary to his court,⁵⁸ or that Hassan Beg Tabrizi and the emissary of the ruler of Golconda paid homage.⁵⁹ Even from less well-known courts, like that of Urgench, does Jahangir document emissaries who arrive.⁶⁰ For each of these individuals Jahangir wrote down the length of time they were at his court, their precise dates of arrival and departure, and the gifts they brought and received. There is even reference in the *Jahangirnama* to a possible false ambassador, Aqam Hajji. At Jahangir's court during March 1608–1609, Aqam Hajji claimed to be an Ottoman ambassador; further in the same passage, however, Jahangir wrote that as no one had come on behalf of the Ottomans or as an ambassador before Aqam Hajji, his professed role was questionable.⁶¹

The importance of diplomatic interaction between Asian nations and the Mughal court is indicated by the naming of so many emissaries and ambassadors from Asian Muslim nations within the *Jahangirnama*. This emphasizes Jahangir's personal worldview as being very much tied up in Asia. The importance Jahangir placed of the traditional nature of these interactions can be seen through the frequently mentioned and named people sent from the Safavid court. In the *Jahangirnama* are thus found thirteen named individuals who visited Jahangir's court on behalf of Shah Abbas.

The reoccurring Safavid diplomats within Jahangir's memoirs should not be seen as Jahangir giving importance to the Safavids, but instead as a means of denoting his own self-importance within the wider political sphere of the Muslim world. The Mughals were one of three powerful Muslim dynasties concurrently existing in the seventeenth century, the Ottomans and the Safavids being the others. The Mughals maintained constant political and economic links with the Safavids, their immediate neighbors to the west. However, the Safavids not only were a Shia dynasty, but also constantly fought with the Mughals over the ownership of the province of Qandahar.⁶² Despite

⁵⁸ Ibid., p. 451.

⁵⁹ Ibid., p. 218.

⁶⁰ Ibid., p. 342. On 28 July 1620, Muhammad Zahid, the emissary of Ghayat Khan of Urgench, arrived at court.

⁶¹ Ibid., p. 95.

⁶² On Mughal-Persian relations, see Jabbari Hooshang, *Trade and Commerce between Iran and India during the Safavid Period* (Delhi: Indian Bibliographies Bureau 2004); Catherine Asher and Cynthia Talbot, *India before Europe* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006); Colin Mitchell, *The Practice of Politics in Safavid Iran: Power, Religion and Rhetoric* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2009). On the Ottomans, Safavids, and Mughals, see Stephen Dale, *The Muslim Empires of the Ottomans, Safavids, and Mughals* (Cambridge: Cambridge

Jahangir's reign being a time of great European interest in the Mughal Empire, these visitors and their home nations did not project the same diplomatic and political importance necessary to be noticed as political players on the Asian world stage. While considering Europe as a novel entity, and understanding the desirable nature of trade with European nations, the Mughals did not group Europe, or England, with the more politically pertinent Asia. It is worth remembering that Jahangir considered his memoirs to be a handbook on kingship, and intended to send copies once it was complete to other rulers as manuals for them to follow.⁶³ Just like Roe's, Jahangir's manuscript was created for a specific audience, written by someone with a specific agenda. This is very likely why there is such a stress on the emissaries and ambassadors from Iran and other Asian countries, as Jahangir was propagating his own power by the arrival of these dignitaries at his court, power that would have been projected once the *Jahangirnama* was sent out to a wider royal audience.

Jahangir's omission of any mention of Roe's name or indication of an English presence at his court in the *Jahangirnama* should therefore be considered in conjunction with Jahangir's worldview. In his memoirs, Jahangir did not deem Roe and England worth mentioning as he did not consider them to be political forces in the region. While he took it as his due that Europeans would come to his court, Jahangir did not view them with the same politico-religious importance as he did diplomats from Asian nations. Taken alongside the absence of Europe as a diplomatic entity within the *Jahangirnama*, the appearance of a specific European artist is notable. Hunarman (a title meaning "artisan") was mentioned twice by Jahangir, once as the Frank who created a magnificent throne for him and "who has no equal in the arts of goldsmithing, carving and other skills,"⁶⁴ and again when Jahangir lists the gifts he has given to Hunarman.⁶⁵ The artisan is presented broadly as a European, without the inclusion of a specific nationality; it would seem that in Jahangir's eyes European nations are one and the same or interchangeable.

Subrahmanyam's statement that the English did not appear to make an impressive mark on Mughal memory during the seventeenth

University Press, 2010); William Floor and Edmund Herzig, eds., *Iran and the World in the Safavid Age* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2011); Douglas Streusand, *Islamic Gunpowder Empires: Ottomans, Safavids, and Mughals* (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 2011).

⁶³ Jahangir, *Jahangirnama*, p. 271.

⁶⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 298.

⁶⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 299.

century⁶⁶ certainly appears evident throughout the *Jahangirnama*. This is contradicted, however, by visual evidence from Jahangir's reign. Much has already been written on the incredible impact the arrival of Europeans at the Mughal court had on the production of painting, specifically during the reigns of Akbar and Jahangir.⁶⁷ Here, two paintings created in Jahangir's atelier will be discussed to indicate that Roe's time at the Mughal court did in fact have an impact on Jahangir. The first is the famous image of Jahangir preferring a Sufi sheikh to kings in the Freer Gallery of Art in Washington D.C.,⁶⁸ and the second is a painting in the British Museum in London of Jahangir presenting a courtier with a robe of honor while a European identified as Roe watches from the audience.⁶⁹

The Freer painting, dated between 1615 and 1618, depicts an allegorical image of Jahangir seated atop a large hourglass handing a book to a Sufi Sheikh, watched by an Ottoman sultan, James I, and the painter of the scene, Bichitr. The appearance of James I's portrait in this painting is a unique occurrence;⁷⁰ from Roe's journal it is known that he gifted a portrait of James I to Jahangir and that this portrait was displayed at the Nouruz festivals in 1616 and 1617.⁷¹ It is almost certain

⁶⁶ See, for example, chapter 6, "The Company and the Mughals between Sir Thomas Roe and Sir William Norris," in Subrahmanyam's *Connected History*.

⁶⁷ A full listing is not possible, but some key recent sources to mention include M. C. Beach, *Mughal and Rajput Painting* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992); G. A. Bailey, *The Jesuits and the Grand Mogul: Renaissance Art at the Imperial Court in India, 1580–1630* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution, 1998); G. A. Bailey, *Art of the Jesuit Missions in Asia and Latin America, 1542–1774* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1999); S. P. Verma, *Flora and Fauna in Mughal Art* (Mumbai: Marg Publications, 1999); Susan Stronge, *Painting for the Mughal Emperor: The Arts of the Book 1560–1660* (London: V&A Museum Press, 2002); Anna Jackson and Amin Jaffer, eds., *Encounters: The Meeting of Asia and Europe 1500–1800* (London: V&A Publishers, 2004); Ebba Koch, *Mughal Art and Imperial Ideology* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2005); M. C. Beach, E. Fischer, and B. N. Goswamy, eds., *Masters of Indian Painting* (Zurich: Artibus Asiae, 2011).

⁶⁸ *Jahangir Preferring a Sufi Shaikh to Kings*, ca. 1615–1618; Freer accession no. F1942.15a, <http://www.asia.si.edu/collections/singleObject.cfm?ObjectNumber=F1942.15a>.

⁶⁹ *Jahangir Investing a Courtier with a Robe of Honour Watched by Sir Thomas Roe, English Ambassador to the Court of Jahangir at Agra from 1615–18, and Others*, ca. 1616, British Museum no. 1933.0610.0.1, http://www.britishmuseum.org/research/collection_online/collection_object_details.aspx?objectId=231669&partId=1.

⁷⁰ It should be noted here that there are multiple images produced by the Mughal court in which Europeans or European subject matter feature prominently as the primary subject of the painting or as part of the wider scene. During Akbar's reign images of the Portuguese and other Europeans start being represented by Mughal artists. Actual portraits were created, as well as generic European representation within depictions of Mughal court scenes, although the latter were rarer.

⁷¹ Describing the scene for the Nouruz festivities on 11 March 1616: "at the vpper end were sett out the pictures of the King of England, the Queene, my lady Elizabeth, the Count-

that the particular image of James I portrayed by Bichitr is the same one that entered the Mughal court via Roe.⁷² The almost identical nature of James I's depiction in the Mughal painting and portraits created by John de Critz in the first decade of the seventeenth century was first noted by M. C. Beach.⁷³ De Critz held the title serjeant painter, meaning that he created official portraits of the English king that were sent as ambassadorial gifts, and so Roe must have had some of de Critz's portraits of the English monarch to present to the Mughal court.⁷⁴ The appearance of the English king in Bichitr's painting can therefore be directly related to Roe's presence at Jahangir's court. While it can be gathered from Roe's absence within the *Jahangirnama* that Jahangir considered Roe a peripheral figure, this painting shows that Roe's presence at the Mughal court expanded Jahangir's worldview. James I does not, to Jahangir, represent England; instead, he symbolizes a more expansive theme, Europe. Barbour rightly states that James I is a "representative 'Frankish' monarch in the scene," but his contention that the inclusion of James I indicates an implicit Mughal acknowledgment of European imperial aspiration and an interest in English demeanor⁷⁵ should be questioned. I would argue that this interpretation is the complete opposite of the intended meaning of the painting. Pictorially represented is Jahangir's worldview, with Europe being subordinated to the Mughal padshah, along with the Ottoman sultan, representing the Muslim (Asian) world; the image is a glorification of Jahangir as the literal "World Seizer."⁷⁶ This meaning appears more evident when this image is viewed as part of the wider group of allegorical paintings of Jahangir produced around the same time, the others of which show Jahangir as a more powerful ruler than Shah Abbas and conquering his rivals in the Deccan. Collectively within these images Jahangir is seen

esses of Sommersett and Salisbury, and of a Cittizens wif of London; below them another of Sir Thomas Smyth, gouernor of the East India company" (Roe, *Embassy*, p. 143), and again in 1617 (*ibid.*, p. 394).

⁷² M. C. Beach, *The Imperial Image: Paintings for the Mughal Court*, Beach, Freer Gallery of Art (Washington D.C.: Smithsonian Institute, 1981), p. 169.

⁷³ *Ibid.*, p. 169.

⁷⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 29.

⁷⁵ Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, p. 172.

⁷⁶ On his accession to the Mughal throne "Jahangir" was part of the name adopted by the then prince Salim, chosen because of its meaning, "the Seizer of the World." It has been noted that with the appearance of James I in this painting a new phase of European influence in Mughal art has been announced; by 1616, the year in which Jahangir displayed paintings presented to him by Roe at the Nouruz festival, Jesuit influence at the Mughal court was substantially lower than it had previously been. See Susan Stronge, *Made for Mughal Emperors* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2010), p. 140.

as the supreme king of the world, ruling over Europe, the Ottomans and Safavids, and the Deccan.⁷⁷

The British Museum painting, on the other hand, indicates Roe's presence at the Mughal court in a much more straightforward manner, in that he is actually present within the painting. Whereas James I's appearance in the Freer painting is singular in that he is the only European monarch to have this distinction, a small group of diplomats and clergymen from European nations have been identified as being represented in Mughal paintings; this image of Roe is one of them. The appearance of Roe in this court scene represents Roe's presence at Jahangir's court having a direct impact on visual subject matter. In this particular painting there was an element of distinction awarded to Roe and England by his inclusion in the scene, and it serves as a succinct example of Mughal awareness and corroboration of Roe's self-perceived importance at the Mughal court.

CONCLUSION

Sir Thomas Roe's journal and letters and Jahangir's *Jahangirnama* present contrasting views of the perception of reception. The stark differences in Roe's reception at the Mughal court are relayed, with Roe perceiving himself as an important part of Jahangir's inner circle, but being exempt from inclusion within Jahangir's memoirs indicates that in both instances the written works exhibit the respective authors' personal agenda. Neither one can be considered to portray a neutral view of their surroundings.

Barbour writes that Roe's journal and letters "grant Roe rhetorical space to collect himself and exercise the dignity and influence denied him elsewhere."⁷⁸ Roe encountered much difficulty in his interactions with many of the Mughal notables he had to deal with. Taking into account the social environment in which Roe found himself, and the realization that the English were at best marginal players on a wider world stage in Jahangir's worldview, Roe's stress on his worth to Jahangir in his writings can be interpreted as a means by which he could con-

⁷⁷ These allegorical paintings are *Jahangir Entertains Shah 'Abbas of Iran*, ca. 1615–1620, and *Jahangir Embracing Shah Abbas*, ca. 1618, by Abu'l Hasan, both in the Freer Gallery of Art, Smithsonian Institute, Washington D.C.; and *Jahangir Shooting the Head of Malik Ambar*, ca. 1616, by Abu'l Hasan, in the Chester Beatty Library, Dublin.

⁷⁸ Barbour, *Before Orientalism*, p. 147.

vey how well suited he was for his task as ambassador. Furthermore, by creating an intimate relationship with the emperor in his writings, and citing examples of how he was so well placed within the Mughal court, Roe presented himself to an English audience as an important main character within the wider Mughal tableau.⁷⁹ The stress in these instances is not on Roe as an ambassador, but on him as a privileged individual. An additional result of this was, therefore, that England was projected within Roe's "play" as superlative to all other foreign entities at the Mughal court, particularly the Portuguese and Safavids.

Roe's self-perceived consequence was not at all reflected within Jahangir's memoirs, in which it was clear that Jahangir's worldview was one that placed the Mughal Empire at the center of a wider political arena that encompassed Asia. England was permitted to join this arena only once Jahangir incorporated her into his wider worldview. Even then, this inclusion did not take the form of England being considered politically important. Instead, Roe's time at Jahangir's court resulted in direct representations of Roe and James I in paintings created by the Mughal atelier. While from a political and diplomatic standpoint there is validity to Mitchell's claim that the Mughals were indifferent to James I and England,⁸⁰ *Jahangir Preferring a Sufi Shaikh to Kings* and *Jahangir Investing a Courtier with a Robe of Honour Watched by Sir Thomas Roe* can be discussed in terms of Roe and his embassy having an impact on Jahangir's wider worldview. In these two paintings it is possible to see that there was a curiosity and awareness of the English at Jahangir's court that was not reflected within the *Jahangirnama*. Taking into account both the written and visual sources, while it is still not possible to exhibit from the Mughal viewpoint a great importance placed on Roe at Jahangir's court, it is permissible to instead say that his presence, and that of England, was felt by Jahangir and used to expand the *Padshah's* visual imagery of political power. At this time, England as a political force within South Asia was negligible. No one could have known that she would go on to have a greater political impact on South Asia than ever envisioned.

⁷⁹ Subrahmanyam alludes to the idea that Roe wanted his readership to believe that there was a measure of understanding between Jahangir and Roe, and that in order for his to project the image of a successful embassy, it must be perceived that he was on intimate terms with Jahangir. See Subrahmanyam, *Connected Histories*, pp. 150–152.

⁸⁰ Mitchell, *Sir Thomas Roe*, p. 167.